

Shutdown could be in cards for Oct. 1

Congress leaves with no resolution

By Riley Beggin and Theodoric Meyer
WASHINGTON POST

Congress headed out of Washington on Friday after spending legislation stalled in the Senate, leaving only two workdays to resolve a stalemate before a potential government shutdown would begin on Oct. 1.

The House passed a Republican-backed measure earlier in the day, largely along party lines, that would push the shutdown deadline to Nov. 21. But then the Senate rejected a Democrat-led proposal that would keep the government open through Oct. 31, as well as implement several Democratic priorities on health care and government spending, and also failed to pass the House bill.

The votes leave Congress without a solution to keep the government open past Sept. 30, when the fiscal year expires. Senators are leaving town for Rosh Hashanah until Sept. 29, when Republicans and Democrats will regroup just ahead of the deadline. House GOP leaders announced Friday afternoon that their members will not come back to town before the funding deadline — forcing the upper chamber to accept the Republican-backed measure.



House minority leader Hakeem Jeffries pushed for health care on Friday.

Ex-federal workers feel pinch as they seek new jobs

By Julian E.J. Sorapuru
GLOBE STAFF

WASHINGTON — Sara Kirwin has a personal mission statement: Contribute to the betterment of humanity by empowering others to do the same. For two decades, Kirwin felt she fulfilled that objective working in IT for the Justice Department.

Then came the Trump administration's plan to shrink the federal bureaucracy, spearheaded in the early months of this year by Elon Musk's Department of Government Efficiency.

Still, Kirwin was determined to remain a civil servant. After all, she had survived presidential transitions and government downsizing before.

But as the scale of DOGE's federal workforce purge became clear and new policies like the return-to-office order were implemented, Kirwin began to reconsider her stance.

In late March, when the Justice Department offered her a severance package including pay

Gas bill hikes 'outrageous,' Healey says

Calls for pushback on proposals by utilities to increase winter rates

By Samantha J. Gross
GLOBE STAFF

On a wintry day in March, as people were reeling from high heating bills, Governor Maura Healey promised to explore “every single thing we can do as a state government” to drive down energy costs.

“People were absolutely flabbergasted by what they got in the mail,” she said, referring to

monthly heating bills that for some households hit \$500 a month, or more.

A few months later, she unveiled a bill that proposed to reduce energy charges by billions of dollars. The legislation has yet to pass, but now Healey's resolve — and that of consumers — is about to be tested yet again after the state's utility companies filed for winter-season

rates for natural gas that would increase monthly bills anywhere from 4 percent for National Grid to as much as 17 percent for Eversource.

“These rate hikes are outrageous,” Healey said in a statement. “I am urging the DPU to scrutinize this proposal and push back on Eversource. We need to lower costs for families and businesses, especially as we head into winter.”

Ultimately, the fate of the rate increases is in the hands of the Department of Public Utili-

ties; Healey has appointed two of the three commissioners who oversee the agency.

Last winter, customers faced even larger double-digit increases in heating charges. Outrage from consumers who said they have trouble paying those bills prompted a bipartisan group of 22 state senators to send a letter to the DPU complaining that utilities should not have “free rein to impose unpredictable and excessive financial burdens on ratepayers.” Eversource said much of the

rate increase for this winter is to underwrite maintenance costs and investments in its gas infrastructure, while only a small portion is attributed to the cost of buying natural gas from suppliers, and to charges associated with public benefits, such as energy efficiency programs.

If approved by the DPU, Eversource will begin charging the higher rate on Nov. 1. The company said households that use an average amount of gas

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TURNING POINT



JOHN TLUMACKI/GLOBE STAFF

With the Financial District in the background, Nelli Chukanivska of Ukraine took part in the Red Bull Cliff Diving World Series, which returned to Boston on Friday. The best cliff divers from around the world dived from as high as 90 feet from platforms attached to the roof of the Institute of Contemporary Art. The event will continue on Saturday with the finals.

‘Don’t get me wrong, I know it’ll be a process. But I’m not worried.’

DOULEY OLIVIER, who is working to become a lab technician

Ambitious trainees unfazed by biotech’s struggles

Programs fill up even with positions scarce

By Marin Wolf
GLOBE STAFF

Each morning for eight weeks, Douley Olivier dragged himself out of bed at 5 a.m. to drop his girlfriend at work so he could drive her car across Dorchester to train as a lab technician in the biotechnology industry.

Each day for six hours, he took classes and practiced techniques, such as using a micropipette to draw exactly 1 millimeter of blood-red food dye and deposit it into beakers of water. And when he was done, he traded his white lab coat for an apron and worked evening catering jobs.

Olivier knew the odds were stacked against him as he tried to make the transition from chef's assistant to lab technician during a sharp

downturn in the biotech sector. But still, when the alarm went off in the early hours of the morning, he again found his way to the Biotech Career Foundations training program.

Olivier, 27, is among the scores of local workers who see the promise of biotechnology even as venture capitalists and other investors pull away from the sector. Enrollments in entry-level training programs are holding steady or growing despite the declining number of placements into full-time positions.

At the Biotech Career Foundations program, run by the nonprofit workforce training group Bioversity, placements have fallen to 50 percent from 75 percent in 2024. But the program is still filling its classes and on track to

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JOHN TLUMACKI/GLOBE STAFF

Douley Olivier put red dye into a test tube as Jahl King looked on as part of Bioversity's training program.

A change on COVID shots

Health Secretary Robert F. Kennedy Jr.'s vaccine advisers added confusion to the issue, declining to recommend the shots for anyone and leaving the choice up to those who want one. Previously, the vaccinations had been urged as a routine step in the fall for nearly everyone. **A2.**

Former Harvard president Claudine Gay focused on pressure from donors as a prime threat to higher education. **B1.**

Three allies of Arthur T. Demoulas were let go by Market Basket's board of directors as the purge continues. **D1.**

A deal was reached to end a strike that disrupted trash pickup in several Greater Boston communities. **B1.**

Three Russian fighter aircraft entered Estonian airspace without permission and stayed there for 12 minutes. **A4.**

Pumpkin slice

Saturday: Sunny, much cooler. High 63-68. Low 50-55.

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Weather and Comics, D4-5.

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